



Fig. 5: Recorded stereo waveform in Audacity frame

Cleaning the cassette and checking its audio quality

If the cassette has not been used for a long period, there might be a lot of dust and fungus in the tape. Remove dust and clean the cassette properly. To remove fungus, play both sides of the cassette in the player before recording. If dirt accumulates on the tape head, noise will be generated and volume reduced. So thoroughly clean the tape head and pinch roller using spirit or some head-cleaning fluid.

To check the tape quality, play the cassette completely in the player. If there is no clicking or whistling sound, load the tape in the player and press 'Play' button. Open the Audacity frame and click 'Record' button. Music will be heard through the speaker. Adjust the volume control and bass treble control of the tape recorder to the middle position so that the audio is clear without much noise. Check the recorded track for assessing the quality. If it is alright, stick to the settings of the tape recorder for recording.

Recording

Now you are going to retrieve your melodies from the audio cassette. Open the Audacity frame and play the cassette. Press 'Record' button (pink) in the tool bar. Music will be recorded. You can see the waveform (two for

stereo) in the Audacity frame. Broken waves indicate noise. After recording completes, press 'Stop' button (yellow) to terminate recording.

Noise removal and normalisation

After recording completes, the track must be normalised. Select the entire track by pressing Control A (Ctrl+A) and verify for any break or straight line representing the noise. If there are straight lines, point the cursor to the site of noise. Click dropdown tab 'Effects' in the tool bar, select 'Noise Removal' and press 'Get Noise Profile.' Noise will be removed. Repeat the process to remove all the noise from the track.

Alternatively, the noise from the entire track can be removed by giving command to Audacity. For this, go to 'Effects' tab and click 'Noise Removal.' The software will identify the noise and remove it.

After noise removal, the waveform should be normalised. This will allow you to correct the 'DC Offset' (vertical displacement of the track) and amplify the wave to a fixed level of -3 dB. To normalise the track, click 'Effects,' select 'Normalise' and click 'OK.' The 'Effects' menu also has provisions like bass boost, change pitch, change speed, compression and echo. Modify the track as you like. Details are available

in the help menu.

Saving the project

Now the audio track is normalised for saving. You can save the file in 'wave' or 'MP3' format. If you want to split and label individual songs, click 'Audio' and point the cursor at the start of the first song. Click 'Tracks' menu. Choose 'Add Label,' fill in the boxes with the name of the song, author, etc and click 'OK.' Label all the songs in a similar way. Press 'File' menu and click 'Export Multiple' option. Songs will be exported to the folder created.

If you want to save the songs in one MP3 file, open 'File' menu and click 'Export MP3.' The songs will then be saved in MP3 format. Before saving the file, 'Edit ID3' frame will appear. It can be used for labeling the details of the songs. Fill in the boxes and click 'OK.' Now the songs are in the digital format saved as MP3. These can be played using any audio software such as Winamp or Media player or copied to a CD for playing in a CD player.

Creating a DVD format

Once you have digitalised your favourite melodies, it is possible to store thousands of songs in one DVD. If you store a song in DVD format, it can be played only on the DVD drive of the computer, and not on a DVD player. To play on a DVD player, the song must be saved using Audio-DVD software. You can burn the songs in a DVD using this software so that all the features supported by the 'DVD-Video' are obtained.

Reviving LP records

If you have a collection of old LP (Long Play) vinyl records, you can retrieve them too using Audacity software, but a preamplifier is necessary between the recorder's output and line-in of the computer. The steps of recording and saving the file are the same as for audio cassette transfer. ●

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